

to release excess water.

In another project, the Kishanganga project on the Jhelum in J&K, Pakistan has protested saying that diversion of flow will adversely impact its agriculture and hydroelectric use. Since India changed the project from a storage scheme to a run of the river plant because of submergence concerns, Pakistan now says that it has to be discussed fresh and that it may create environmental damage to the Neelum valley, a charge Indian officials deny. Diplomatic sources say that

happened since then under the composite dialogue process, but the deadlock hasn't been sorted out.

Tension is mounting on the eastern flank too with Bangladesh as water tops the bilateral disputes agenda. Though the Ganges Water-Sharing Treaty (GWST) was signed between India and Bangladesh in 1996 to resolve the dispute over sharing of water at the Farrakha Barrage, differences continue on Bangladesh's share of water during lean periods. Dhaka has alleged in bilateral meet-

has been demanding the dismantling of existing water treaties, dubbing these as unequal. For India and Nepal it may be a mutually-beneficial relationship if the two countries are able to create a series of hydropower projects that will bring power to India and economic benefits to Nepal, but political issues have derailed any progress. Nepal and India signed the Mahakali Treaty in 1996, but despite ratification by the Nepalese Parliament, the treaty remains stalled. Currently the two countries are engaged in discussions for three big projects—the Pancheshwar Multipurpose project, Saptakosi high dam project and the Karnali project.



“Water is a sensitive issue. We are keen to sort it through bilateral mechanisms.”

PRANAB MUKHERJEE,
Foreign Minister, INDIA

The Mahakali Treaty was signed with Nepal in 1996, but remains stalled. The two countries have signed five agreements and eight bilateral mechanisms exist but the progress has been tardy.

No water treaty or institutional mechanism with China. The ad hoc arrangement is a handicap, and may have dangerous consequences.

the battle is over the use of the waters of the Jhelum, and Pakistan is desperate to complete its own Neelum-Jhelum project to establish first claim over the waters. The water problems between the two do not end here, as a deadlock has ensued since 1987 on the Tulbul navigation project started by India in 1984, on river Jhelum between Baramulla and Anantnag. Pakistan had raised objections and forced India to suspend work on the project. It has been 11 years and more than eight rounds of meetings have

ings that the large number of hydropower projects that India has on the river Ganga have reduced the flow of water. Another thorny issue is the dispute over sharing of the waters of river Teesta where the two countries have not been able to agree to a formula for sharing the water. Now the water resources secretaries are scheduled to meet to settle the issue.

In the case of Nepal too, water issues continue to plague bilateral relations. The Maoist Government, led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal,

India's water woes continue with China that controls a bulk of the rivers originating from the Tibetan plateau flowing into many Asian countries. Already, there are fears that it may be building dams and diverting water of the Upper Brahmaputra river in Tibet. In the long term if these water-related issues stay unresolved they will impede India's growth and would puncture its aspirations of being a major global player. “Water is an important natural resource, and we are willing to settle all disputes under institutional mechanisms that we have, but our neighbours also have to be flexible. Water is scarce and if we settle our disputes and move in for joint projects it will be a win-win relationship for all of us,” says U.N. Panjiar, secretary, Ministry of Water Resources.

There is an urgent need to have an integrated water policy for South Asia to conserve and tap resources in a sustainable manner. Besides, efforts should also be made to develop the concept of a South Asia inland navigation system. SAARC can play a pivotal role here. It may be a good idea to get the private sector involved, but with checks and balances. It will ensure economic interdependence that can help tide over political problems, and hopefully it would be able to stop what may escalate into South Asia's water wars. ■